

Ukraine, U.S. move closer on peace plan

Proposed changes please Kyiv but could be less palatable to Moscow

BY SIOBHÁN O'GRADY, ELLEN FRANCIS AND ROBYN DIXON

KYIV — The United States and Ukraine significantly changed a controversial 28-point plan to end the war following frenzied meetings in Geneva that brought the two sides closer to an agreement after the White House pushed Kyiv to sign off on the plan by Thanksgiving.

The changes, which two Ukrainian officials said were much more palatable to their country, could very well be less acceptable to Russia — the paradox that has long resulted in an impasse over ending the war.

The original draft, presented to Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky in Kyiv last week, made concessions to Moscow that crossed major red lines for Ukraine, spurring outrage from Kyiv and its allies, including Republicans in Congress. Zelensky and top officials have spent the past days in a diplomatic flurry to garner support for a better deal.

A U.S. delegation, led by Secretary of State Marco Rubio, and a Ukrainian team, led by the head of the presidential office, Andriy Yermak, held talks in Geneva over the weekend to hammer through changes to the proposal.

The meetings were “tense and tough” but productive, said Oleksandr Bezz, an adviser to Yermak who participated in the Geneva talks.

He said the Thursday deadline now appears more flexible than it had before. “It’s not a code red. It’s more important to finalize the text.”

SEE UKRAINE ON A14

Fir ... Ellipse



SALWAN GEORGES/THE WASHINGTON POST

First lady Melania Trump receives the official 2025 White House Christmas tree — which arrived via horse-drawn carriage at the North Portico on Monday — while members the United States Marine Band, also known as “The President’s Own,” provided some holiday music. The fir was grown at a farm in Sidney Township, Michigan.

Felon paid lobbyists nearly \$1M in bid for pardon

BY MICHAEL KRANISH AND AARON SCHAFER

In April, Alina Habba, the U.S. attorney for New Jersey, extolled her office’s role in the sentencing of a former nursing home magnate to three years in prison for defrauding the government of \$38 million. The man, Joseph Schwartz, was alleged to have overseen a “collapsed nursing home empire” and “willfully failed to pay employment taxes, Habba’s announcement said.

Around that time, Schwartz paid \$960,000 to two lobbyists “seeking a federal pardon,” according to their lobbying filing.

While many people have sought pardons from President Donald Trump, few could afford to spend such a sum to seek their freedom. The disclosure provides a rare look at how federal convicts are maneuvering to gain clemency during Trump’s second term and at some of the people offering to help them.

The lobbyists, right-wing pro-

vocateurs Jack Burkman and Jacob Wohl, noted on the disclosure form that they had been convicted of telecommunications fraud in Ohio in connection with a robocall scheme designed to deter the turnout of minority voters. They also face sentencing next month in Michigan on a similar robocall case and have been subject to millions of dollars in fines in a related case brought by the Federal Communications Commission, according to state and federal authorities. For years, the

pair have injected themselves into politics, such as alleging without evidence in 2018 that there were sexual assault claims against special counsel Robert S. Mueller III.

It is not clear what Burkman and Wohl did for Schwartz. But on Nov. 14, seven months after Habba celebrated Schwartz’s conviction, Trump granted Schwartz a “full and unconditional” pardon.

Liz Oyer, a former U.S. pardon SEE SCHWARTZ ON A10

Comey, James cases tossed

JUDGE: PROSECUTOR SERVING ILLEGALLY

Big setback for Trump’s efforts to jail his rivals

BY JEREMY ROEBUCK AND SALVADOR RIZZO

A federal judge dismissed the criminal cases against former FBI director James B. Comey and New York Attorney General Letitia James on Monday, delivering an emphatic blow to President Donald Trump’s rushed efforts to engineer prosecutions of two of his prominent foes.

U.S. District Judge Cameron McGowan Currie ruled that Lindsey Halligan, the prosecutor overseeing both cases, had been unlawfully appointed as interim U.S. attorney for the Eastern District of Virginia and, therefore, indicts she single-handedly secured against Comey and James must be thrown out.

The judge said the Justice Department could seek a new indictment against James under a lawfully appointed prosecutor. In Comey’s case, though, Currie suggested that the time for doing so has run out.

Comey’s lawyers had argued that he cannot be recharged now because the five-year deadline to bring a case against him expired days after he was indicted in September. Currie appeared to endorse that view in her written opinion Monday. She cited rulings by other courts that have held that if an indictment is invalid at the time it is issued, it does not pause the clock on the

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Mortgage fraud cases: A witness exposes unusual tactics. **A5**

As ICE targets cities, empty school desks often follow

BY JUSTINE MCDANIEL AND MARÍA LUISA PAÚL

The effects of the Trump administration’s immigration crackdown in Charlotte tore through schools last week, disrupting learning as more than 20 percent of students stayed home from class.

At many schools, children were either missing or rattled. One wore a tag that read, “I’m a U.S. citizen”; another carried an American passport to elementary school. Two kindergartners showed up to class with whistles around their necks to blow if they saw immigration agents.

“You can’t get ready for this type of disruption,” said Amanda Thompson, president of the Charlotte-Mecklenburg teachers union. “All of our students are being affected.”

Charlotte became the latest example of how the Trump administration’s sweeping campaign to deport undocumented immigrants — including activity by immigration agents near schools in some places — has traumatized kids, put new burdens on teachers and administrators, and dramatically altered the

SEE ICE ON A20



HEIDI LEVINE/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Avraham Binnenfeld, 28, at his home in Tel Aviv, is soon moving to Switzerland.

Israel facing a wave of emigration

Fear and discontent have pushed thousands to leave in new brain drain

BY SHIRA RUBIN

TEL AVIV — Avraham Binnenfeld had grown so dismayed with Israeli politics that he was preparing to move abroad when Hamas’s brutal attack on southern Israel in October 2023 upended the country — and his plans. Instead, Binnenfeld said, he immediately mobilized for

army reserve duty, spending sleepless nights worried about his two brothers in combat units and freezing his plans to emigrate.

But now, weeks after Israel and Hamas reached a ceasefire in the Gaza war, Binnenfeld is packing up to move.

“Being only a few hours from a siren, a terror attack, a region-

al war, a missile from Iran, our brothers in Gaza and in Lebanon, it’s all so much,” he said. He added that he could deal with it all if he believed the government, contrary to its current course, was steering Israel in the right direction. “I need to know that all that suffering is for a good cause.”

SEE ISRAEL ON A15

Republicans’ split on AI: Move fast or add guardrails?

Trump signs order to quicken development as allies aim to protect jobs

BY EMILY DAVIES AND CAT ZAKRZEWSKI

A think tank with deep ties to the White House on Monday announced a \$10 million initiative to develop artificial intelligence policies aimed at supporting workers, as President Donald Trump signed an executive order to accelerate AI research and development.

The plan signals an effort to equip the Republican Party with MAGA-friendly messaging and policy on the emerging technology, amid growing worries that artificial intelligence could automate jobs, increase unemployment and drive up energy costs for consumers. The president’s focus to date on swiftly developing AI to remain competitive with China has aligned the administration with tech industry leaders and alienated some of his prominent supporters.

Monday’s executive order creates the “Genesis Mission,” which will marshal federal computing resources and datasets to accelerate AI research to address “technology challenges of na-

tional importance.” Administration officials portrayed the program as the most significant effort to amass federal science resources since the Apollo 11 mission to land a man on the moon, but they did not announce any new funding for the effort.

The administration is looking to expand the government’s use of AI as the America First Policy Institute (AFPI), a powerful conservative think tank that served as a holding house for top Trump officials in the years between his administrations, is developing a plan focused on workers whose jobs might be affected by the technology. During Trump’s time out of office, the AFPI developed immigration, trade and taxation policies that the administration quickly implemented when Trump returned to power. Half a dozen Trump Cabinet secretaries have ties to the organization, which was co-founded by Brooke Rollins, now agriculture secretary.

As described by AFPI staffers, the strategy will focus on creating high-paying manufacturing jobs, protecting children from the dangers of AI and preventing foreign adversaries from deploying the technology against the American people.

Chris Stewart, a Republican former congressman who chairs the initiative, described the plan

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The Washington Post
Year 148, No. 54411

